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Cloelia

Cloelia (Ancient Greek: Κλουλία)^[1] was a legendary woman from the early history of ancient Rome.

Biography

She was one of the women taken hostage by Lars Porsena as a part of the peace treaty which ended the war between Rome and Clusium in 508 BC.^[2] Ancient historians present two different stories explaining her escape. The first version of Cloelia's escape recognizes that the female hostages went to the river to bathe. Having persuaded their guards to leave them alone at the river, in order to remain modest, they swam across the river into Roman territory. The second version claims that Cloelia escaped from the Etruscan camp, leading away a group of Roman virgins. According to Valerius Maximus, she fled upon a horse, and swam across the river Tiber through a barrage of hostile darts, thus bringing her band of girls to safety.

When Porsena learnt of their escape, he quickly sent emissaries to Rome demanding her return. However, Porsena soon reconsidered, deciding that her deeds were worthy of admiration equal to that of Horatius Cocles and Gaius Mucius Scaevola. He declared to the Romans that if she were restored to him he would send her back to Rome safe and inviolate, but if his demands were not met he should regard the treaty as broken.

The Romans agreed to the conditions and returned the pledge of peace, as the treaty required. Porsena praised Cloelia on her arrival and, as a reward for her heroism, promised to release half the share of his hostages of her choice. It is said that she selected the young boys, as was unanimously decided by the hostages, since they were particularly at risk of abuse.^[3]

Once peace had been established, the Romans celebrated her valour by building a statue of a maiden seated on a horse, set up on the summit of the Via Sacra.^[4]



Cloelia in the 16th-century *Promptuarii Iconum Insigniorum*



16th century piece by Pierre Milan and René Boyvin depicting one account of Cloelia's escape



Cultural depictions

Cloelia has been depicted in several paintings and in the libretto *Il trionfo di Clelia* (1762) by Pietro Metastasio.

She was also portrayed by Sylvia Syms in the 1961 Italian movie *Le Vergini di Roma*.

See also

- Cloelia gens
- Gaius Mucius Scaevola
- Horatius Cocles

References

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- Livy, Titus. *The History of Rome* (<http://www.perseus.tufts.edu/hopper/text?doc=Perseus%3Atext%3A1999.02.0151%3Abook%3D2%3Achapter%3D13>). p. 2.13.
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Sources

- Livy, *Ab urbe condita*, 2.13 (https://en.m.wikisource.org/wiki/From_the_Founding_of_the_City/Book_2#13)
- Valerius Maximus, *Factorum ac dictorum memorabilium*, 3.2.2 (<http://attalus.org/translate/valerius3a.html#2.2>)



The Flight of Cloelia (1623) by Cornelis van Poelenburgh



Cloelia Crossing the Tiber (1630/40) by Rubens

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